

Red-billed tropicbird

Phaethon aethereus

- ↔ 31–32 in (78–81 cm)
- 📍 E. Pacific, C. Atlantic, and N. Indian oceans
- ⊗ Common

This seabird spends most of its time in the air, flying over the tropical oceans in search of fish and squid that it catches by plunge-diving into the sea. Both sexes have white plumage, black wingtips, and two long, white tail streamers that create a spectacular effect as they flick from side to side during the birds' aerial courtship displays. Like many ocean birds, it breeds in large colonies on remote islands.

Dalmatian pelican

Pelecanus crispus

- ↔ 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m)
- 📍 SE. Europe, S. and SW. Asia, NE. Africa
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Silvery white, with black wingtips, this is one of the largest flying birds. Its expandable throat pouch turns a rich reddish orange in the breeding season. Sociable and intelligent, the pelican feeds in small flocks that often cooperate to drive fish into shallow water, where they are more easily caught. Each bird scoops up a mass of water and fish, filling its throat pouch, which it then drains of water by tipping its head back.

Brown pelican

Pelecanus occidentalis

- ↔ 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- 📍 North, Central, and South America, Caribbean
- ⊗ Common

Although similar to other pelicans in build, this is the only pelican that feeds by plunge-diving instead of fishing from the surface. Typically, it searches for prey by gliding low over the water. When it sights a fish, it flies up to gain height, then folds its wings back and plunges into the sea. As it enters the water, it opens its bill to trap its victim in its expanded throat pouch.

Northern gannet

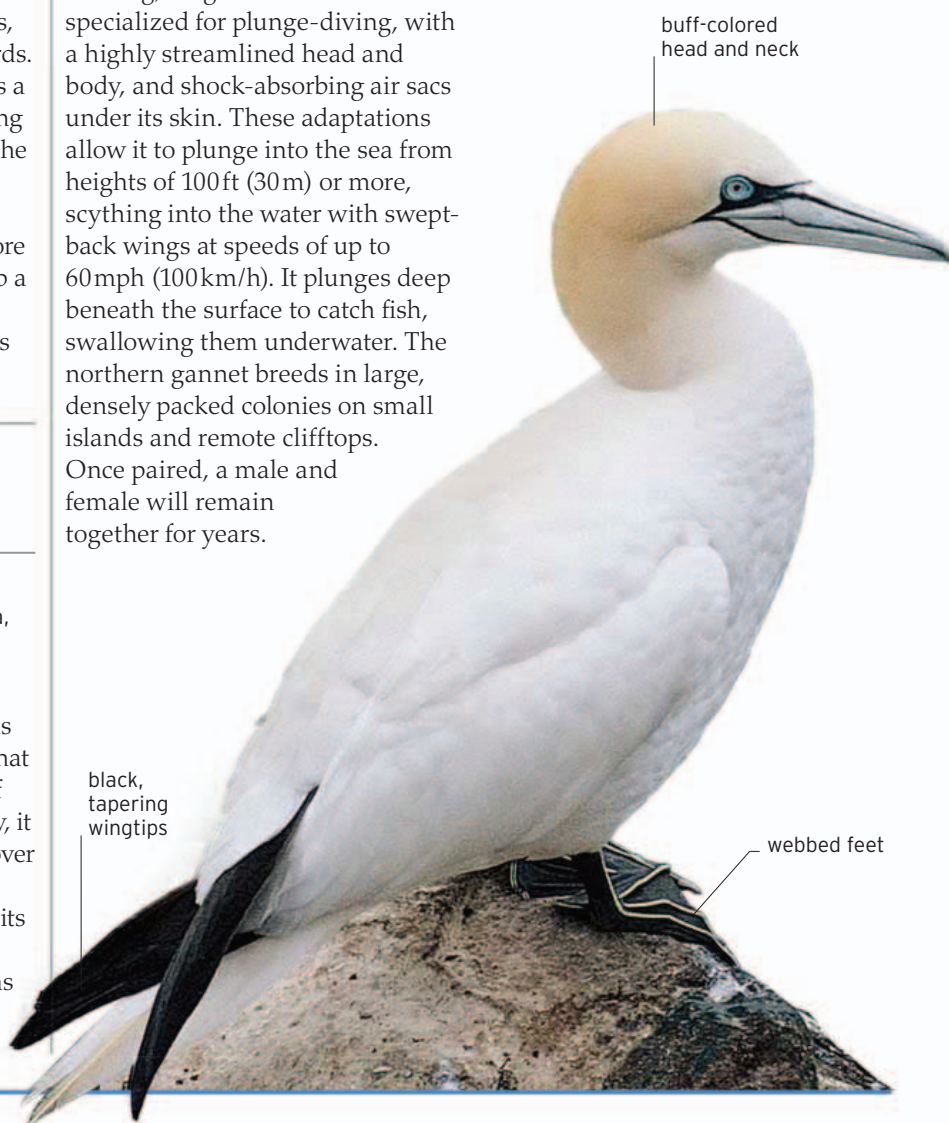
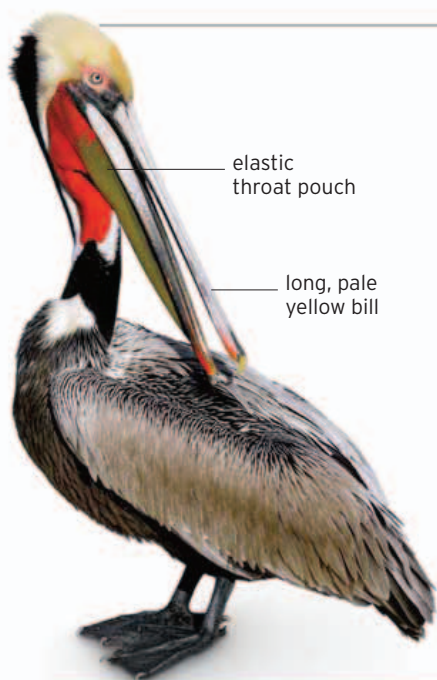
Morus bassanus

- ↔ 32–35 in (80–90 cm)
- 📍 N. Atlantic, Mediterranean
- ⊗ Common

This big, long-billed seabird is specialized for plunge-diving, with a highly streamlined head and body, and shock-absorbing air sacs under its skin. These adaptations allow it to plunge into the sea from heights of 100 ft (30 m) or more, scything into the water with swept-back wings at speeds of up to 60 mph (100 km/h). It plunges deep beneath the surface to catch fish, swallowing them underwater. The northern gannet breeds in large, densely packed colonies on small islands and remote clifftops. Once paired, a male and female will remain together for years.

Other species

- Great white pelican
Pelecanus onocrotalus » p189
- Shoebill
Balaeniceps rex » p190



Birds of prey

Order Falconiformes

California condor

Gymnogyps californianus

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- 📍 W. US (California, Arizona)
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Rescued from certain extinction by captive breeding and released back into the wild, this relative of the majestic Andean condor is the largest flying bird in North America and also one of the most endangered. It searches for carrion by soaring high over open country

on its broad black wings and once ranged as far east as Florida. Now reduced to just a few hundred individuals, its future is still in the balance; many have died from lead poisoning as a result of eating animals killed by hunters using lead ammunition. California condors generally mate for life, producing one chick every two years.



Osprey

Pandion haliaetus

- ↔ 22–25 in (56–64 cm)
- 📍 Worldwide (except Antarctica)
- ⊗ Common

This large bird of prey has an almost worldwide range. It is found on coasts, lakes, and large rivers. The osprey is a fish hunter, famous for the way it plunges into the water feet-first to seize large fish with its powerful curved talons. Its feet have spiny soles that give it a firm grip on its prey as it flies off to a perch to tear it apart with its hooked bill. During the breeding season, pairs mate following dramatic courtship displays by the males.